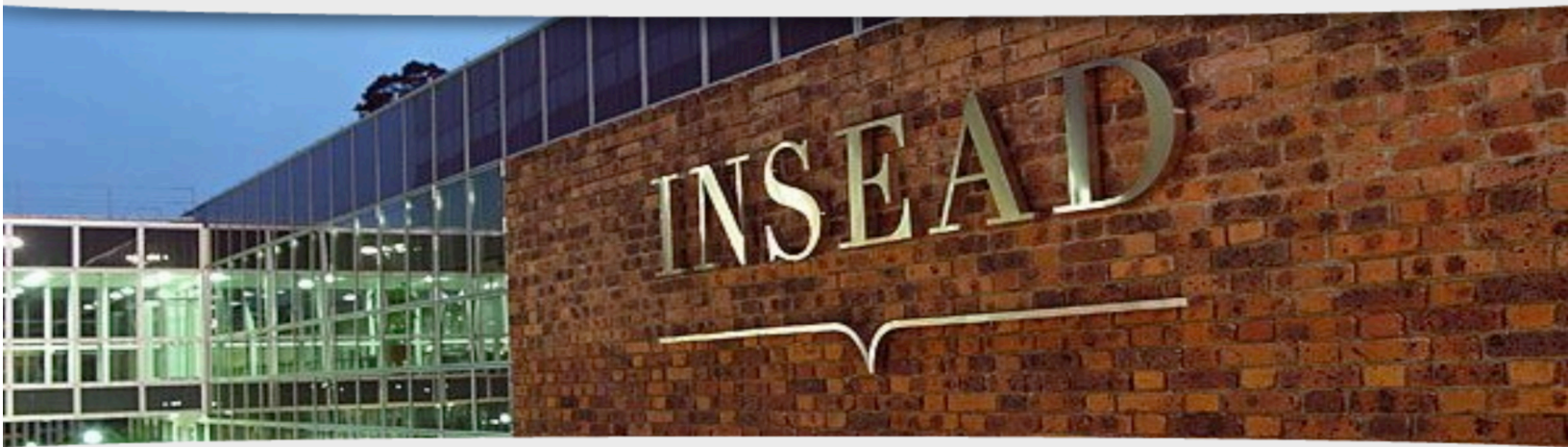




FORTUNA ADMISSIONS
INSIDER'S TOP TIPS
FOR APPLYING TO
INSEAD

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ABOUT THE SCHOOL

"The Business School for the World" is how INSEAD positions itself, and it lives up to the promise with 80+ nationalities on its MBA program, and an equally diverse faculty and alumni network. International diversity has been part of the school's DNA since its inception, over 50 years ago, when it pioneered the one-year MBA. Today the school has the largest MBA program in the world, with more than 1,000 students per year, spread across two intakes (one class starts in January and another in September) and across two campuses (Fontainebleau, a small town 70km from Paris, and in Singapore). MBAs also have the option of taking electives on the school's Abu Dhabi campus, and exchange to top US schools. The school is also proud of providing an international platform for recruitment, with graduates taking up positions in over 50 countries around the world each year.

The program is very much a General Management degree, but has a strong elective offering, enabling students to deepen their knowledge in a wide range of areas. Entrepreneurship is a particularly popular academic area, with 80% of students taking at least one entrepreneurship elective.

STRENGTHS AND SPECIALIZATIONS

General Management, Entrepreneurship, Finance, Strategy, Impact investing, Energy, Strategy

INCOMING CLASS

MBA Class Size: 1,039 Course length: 1 year
Admissions Selectivity: 32% Yield: 80.65%
Total Tuition: €85,500 Class with a scholarship: 31%

POST-MBA CAREERS

Sector: Consulting 36%; Finance 13%; Tech 17%; Consumer Goods/Luxury 6%
Top Recruiters: McKinsey, BCG, Bain & Co., Amazon, Strategy&, A.T. Kearney
Avg. Base Salary: \$110,400 Employment within 3 months: 91%

MBA RANKINGS	2010	2011	2012	2013	2014	2015	2016	2017	2018
BusinessWeek	1	-	2	-	5	3	2	1	3
Financial Times	5	4	6	6	5	4	1	1	2
Forbes	-	1	-	2	-	1	-	2	-
The Economist	23	19	19	26	18	8	13	4	4

ADMISSIONS

Avg. Age: 29 yrs Avg. GMAT: 709
Int'l Students: 96% Female Students: 33%

Deadlines for Sept 2020 Intake

(class of July 2021): R1 – Sept 18, '19 R2 – Nov. 6, '19
R3 – Jan. 15, '20 R4 – Feb 26, '20

Deadlines for January 2021 Intake

(Class of Dec. 2021): R1 – Mar 11 '20 R2 – May 6, '20
R3 – June 24, '20 R4 – July 28, '20

Sources: INSEAD, BusinessWeek, Financial Times, Forbes, MBA50



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Career Questions:

1. Briefly summarise your current (or most recent) job, including the nature of work, major responsibilities, and where relevant, employees under your supervision, size of budget, clients/products and results achieved. (limit: 200 words)
2. What would be your next step in terms of position if you were to remain in the same company? (limit: 200 words)
3. Please give a full description of your career since graduating from university. Describe your career path with the rationale behind your choices. (limit: 300 words)
4. Discuss your short and long term career aspirations with or without an MBA from INSEAD. (limit: 100 words)

(Optional) If you are currently not working or if you plan to leave your current employer more than 2 months before the programme starts, please explain your activities and occupations between leaving your job and the start of the programme.

Motivation Essays:

1. Give a candid description of yourself (who are you as a person), stressing the personal characteristics you feel to be your strengths and weaknesses and the main factors which have influenced your personal development, giving examples when necessary. (limit 500 words)
2. Describe the achievement of which you are most proud and explain why. In addition, describe a situation where you failed. How did these experiences impact your relationships with others? Comment on what you learned. (limit 400 words)
3. Describe all types of extra-professional activities in which you have been or are still involved for a significant amount of time (clubs, sports, music, arts, politics, etc). How are you enriched by these activities? (limit 300 words)

(Optional) Is there anything that you have not mentioned in your application that you would like the Admissions Committee to know? (limit 300 words) This section is optional.

Video Essays:

After submitting the INSEAD MBA application, applicants will receive a link to a video interview, asking you 4 questions. This component is mandatory in order for one's application to be considered complete. You have 48 hours after you submit your application for the completion of the video portion.

Note from the INSEAD admissions committee: "We are keen on getting to know you better and believe that through a video you can come to life, so be spontaneous, be creative and be yourself! We look forward to virtually meeting you!"

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By Caroline Diarte Edwards

Caroline served as the INSEAD Director of MBA Admissions, Marketing & Financial Aid. Caroline oversaw all aspects of candidate evaluation and policy decisions during her seven years at INSEAD. As an alumna of INSEAD as well, Caroline knows the MBA experience inside and out.

Tip #1 - Overcoming limited international experience

INSEAD takes great pride in the international diversity of its MBA program: both as regards to the range of nationalities represented, and the international experience of the students. But not everyone at INSEAD has a lot of international experience. Typically, those who gain admission without much experience beyond their own borders are from emerging markets (they may not have had financial means to travel), but can demonstrate that they have the ability to fit in well in an incredibly diverse environment (qualities such as openness, flexibility, curiosity about other cultures, interpersonal skills, maturity – all these elements help). They have also demonstrated that they need to join such an international community – that it will be highly relevant for their future career plans. Someone who has never travelled abroad, and who has no interest in business beyond his or her own national border should think twice before applying.

Tip #2 - When to apply

Many schools advise candidates against applying in the final round. INSEAD, on the other hand, works hard to keep the level of competition fair across all rounds. It makes sense really: they want the best of the entire pool, and do not want to reject someone in the final round who would have been admitted in round 1 (or accept someone in round 1 who would be rejected in round 3 or round 4). They achieve this through making an informed guestimate of expected application volume by round, and through the use of the waitlist for borderline candidates. In general, it is far better to apply in round 3 or 4 with a really well-prepared application, than apply in a rush in round 2. One word of caution though: if predicted application volume for the final round is higher than expected, it is possible that the level of competition could increase. Also, do remember that the earlier you apply and are admitted, the more time you have to get organized and plan your move to campus. Finally, be aware that more scholarship options are available to round 1 and 2 candidates than final round candidates.

Tip #3 - GMAT

The average GMAT at INSEAD is 709; the range is typically around 600 to 800. INSEAD advises candidates to target the 75th percentile on both the verbal and the quant; they look more at this breakdown than at the total score. If you get less than 70th percentile on either part of the test, you better have a very strong academic track record, and/or have a profile that the school loves. So INSEAD is perhaps not as flexible as some top schools as regards the GMAT – this is largely because it is a one year program, so the pace is fast, and the school really needs to be sure you have the academic smarts to keep up. And although many love to hate the GMAT, it is actually a fairly good predictor of academic performance on the INSEAD program.



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Tip #4 - Choice of campus and class

The Admissions Committee takes decisions blind of campus choice – i.e. they cannot see whether you have applied to Fontainebleau or Singapore. So the chances are equal. However this does mean that not all campus preferences can be accommodated – typically, a handful of students will be asked to start on the campus that was not their stated preference, to enable the school to achieve the right class size and a similarly diverse class across campuses.

Application volume for the September entry is slightly higher than for the January entry, but then “yield” (the percentage of admits who actually join the program) is lower for September (because candidates are more likely to be applying for multiple programs). So in fact the level of the competition works out to be exactly the same.

Tip #5 - Language requirement

INSEAD requires two languages to enter the program (fluent English, plus at least a working knowledge of a second language) and a third language to graduate (to a basic level). Most candidates are able to fulfill these requirements fairly easily, but it is sometimes a challenge for native English speakers. INSEAD maintains this policy because the school believes that those who have made the effort to learn another language have demonstrated an interest in another country or culture; they also believe that the ability to speak more than one language opens doors internationally and can be an advantage in an internationally mobile career, as many INSEAD graduates pursue.

Tip #6 - Overcoming a “common” profile

There are some profiles that pour in to the INSEAD admissions office by the hundreds: for example, management consultants based in Europe, or Indian IT professionals. There are times of the year when some of the INSEAD admissions staff are almost drowning under a flood of pale blue (=Indian) files. Whilst INSEAD has no hard and fast quota, they also want to create a diverse class, so in reality, the competition can be tougher for some than for others. If you have a common profile, then you need to be strong across all elements of the application, including your academic profile, your professional track record, your international experience, and your activities and achievements outside of work or study. Try to find some element to your profile that can differentiate you: e.g. a multicultural background, an entrepreneurial side interest, etc.

Tip #7 - Limited work experience

On average, INSEAD students have five to six years work experience, however the range is about two years to 10 years. Remember also that the length of work experience is measured as how long you will have worked by the time you start the program, not how long you have worked by the time you apply. If you would only have two to three years experience by the time you start, you'll need to work hard in your application to demonstrate that you already have some significant professional accomplishments, that you have interesting experience and perspectives to share with team mates who may be further ahead in their careers than you, and that you have the maturity to fit in well with class mates that on average are likely to be a bit older than you.

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Tip #8 - Career-changers

Most INSEAD students are making some significant change in their career. The MBA program measures change across three dimensions: industry, function and country. In fact, typically about 80% make a change on one of these dimensions, and about 25% make a change on all three dimensions. If you are planning a pretty dramatic career change, you could be well advised to join the January intake, so that you can take an internship in July and August (the September entry does not have an internship option).

Having said that, the stats quoted above do not vary much between the January or September entries, so if you are targeting a September start, you can still count on a big change being possible. And while many INSEAD students end up changing their minds about their future plans during the year, be warned that a 10-month program does not give you a lot of time for navel gazing and mulling over infinite options. You need to be ready to make decisions about your future direction fairly quickly, and you also need to be able to juggle an intensive academic schedule with an ongoing and regular investment of time in your job search.

Tip #9 - Showcasing your international experience

International experience is an advantage. But you need to do more than just enumerate your trips or stays abroad. INSEAD wants to see that you have learned from these experiences, that you have gained cultural sensitivity and interesting insights. Also lots of short trips abroad count for less than extended stays e.g. spent working or studying in another country, when you would have had to adapt to and integrate into a new environment.

Tip #10 - Non-traditional candidates

Schools like INSEAD work hard to craft a diverse class – and diversity includes professional backgrounds. There are always several students with non-business backgrounds: doctors, scientists, journalists, and military officers. There have even been performing artists, and a monk! As a non-traditional candidate, you need to demonstrate that you have a clear rationale for taking the MBA: a vision of what you want to achieve – and this has to be credible. The school has to be convinced that you have the skills and drive to make a big career change work. And as with other candidates, you have to demonstrate that you are a high achiever in your work, whatever that may be.

More about Fortuna Admissions:

Fortuna Admissions is a dream team of former MBA Admissions Directors and Officers from the top-tier business schools, including Wharton, INSEAD, Harvard Business School, Stanford GSB, Kellogg Northwestern, LBS, Chicago Booth, Columbia, NYU Stern, IE, Duke Fuqua, UCLA Anderson, Cornell Johnson and Berkeley Haas.

As industry experts, we regularly provide commentary and analysis about b-school admissions for major media around the world. To read our full range of advice visit FortunaAdmissions.com

With our unparalleled collective expertise, we are able to coach you to develop a clear vision of your goals for business school and beyond. We work closely with you throughout the application process and provide expert guidance at every stage to maximize your chances of admission to a top school.

Our free consultations are consistently rated as the best in the industry. To learn more about Fortuna and assess your chances for admission, reserve yours at FortunaAdmissions.com

